Top 5 Business Automation Workflows (v3)

Prepared for: Simon / Dynk

Prepared by: Kryon

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> This is a productisable, client-ready brief describing five automation workflows that are consistently sellable because they map to clear business outcomes.
> v3 is intentionally *less rigid* than v2, while still keeping a clear hierarchy, scannable headings, and implementation-level detail.

Executive overview

Why these 5 workflows win

These five workflows tend to be the fastest path to measurable ROI because they: - sit on high-frequency, high-friction processes (leads, onboarding, invoices, support, HR) - integrate with systems that already exist (CRM, billing, ticketing, HRIS) - convert effort into a metric leadership recognises (revenue conversion, churn, DSO, SLA attainment, time-to-productivity)

Delivery philosophy (how to keep margins healthy)

A useful way to package these offers is to ship a **reusable orchestration layer** once, then configure per-client: - **Orchestrator:** Temporal / AWS Step Functions / n8n / Make / Zapier (choose by complexity) - **Event sources:** webhooks, email parsing, scheduled polls - **Data layer:** small Postgres/SQLite + object store (for idempotency, audit, replay) - **AI layer (optional):** classification, summarisation, drafting with retrieval + citations - **Observability:** run logs, failure alerts, retries, and manual override UI

Common assumptions for cost estimates

The run-cost breakdowns below use a simple, transparent model you can show clients.

Baseline assumptions (adjust per client): - Volume: *1,000 events/month* (leads/tickets/invoices/etc.) unless noted - LLM calls: where used, average 1–2 calls per item - Token usage: ~2,000 input + 500 output tokens per item (classification + draft) - Automation platform: $20–$100/mo (Zapier/Make/n8n hosting) depending on tier - Engineering overhead is not included in “run cost” (it’s in delivery / pricing)

> Note: exact token pricing depends on model choice. The tables show *formulas + example totals* so you can swap in current pricing.

Workflow 1 — Lead qualification (capture → enrich → score → route)

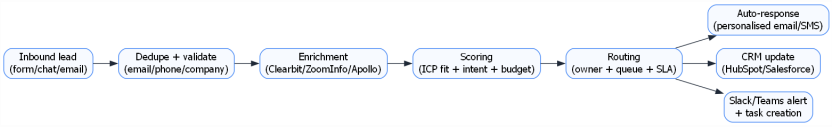
What it does (plain English)

Turns inbound interest into booked meetings faster by automatically validating a lead, enriching it, scoring intent + ICP fit, then routing it to the right rep with a timely personalised response.

Who buys it

- B2B services, SaaS, agencies, consultancies
- any inbound-led motion where speed-to-lead correlates with conversion

Architecture (diagram)



Step-by-step implementation plan (delivery playbook)

Phase A — Discovery (0.5–1 day)

1. Confirm lead sources (forms, chat, inbound email, ads, LinkedIn)
2. Identify "system of record" (HubSpot vs Salesforce, etc.)
3. Define lead stages + ownership rules (territory, round-robin, named accounts)
4. Define the scoring rubric (ICP firmographics + intent + engagement)
5. Confirm response channels (email/SMS/Slack) and compliance constraints

Phase B — Data mapping + idempotency (0.5–1 day)

1. Create field mapping (lead/contact/company/deal)
2. Implement dedupe keys (email, domain, phone)
3. Add an audit table: `lead_id`, `source_event_id`, `status`, `timestamp`, `owner` (this prevents double-processing and enables replay)

Phase C — Enrichment + scoring (1–2 days)

1. Enrichment calls (Clearbit/ZoomInfo/Apollo/etc.)
2. Normalise enrichment output into a single schema
3. Score algorithm (start rules-based; add ML later):
   - ICP fit: industry, company size, geography
   - intent: pageviews, key pages hit, demo request
   - disqualifiers: student email, competitor domain, no budget signals
4. Set thresholds:
   - **Hot** → immediate handoff + meeting link
   - **Warm** → nurture sequence
   - **Cold** → long-term drip + list hygiene

Phase D — Routing + response (1–2 days)

1. Assign owner (territory → queue → round-robin fallback)
2. Create CRM tasks + SLA timers
3. Auto-response templates with personalisation (industry + pain-point)
4. Internal notifications (Slack/Teams)

Phase E — QA, monitoring, handover (0.5–1 day)

1. Test harness with 30–50 sample leads
2. Failure modes: enrichment timeout, CRM rate limits, duplicate submissions
3. Alerting rules:
   - "Hot lead not assigned within 2 minutes"
   - "Enrichment error rate > 5% in 1 hour"
4. Handover docs + admin runbook

Orchestration pseudocode (implementation sketch)

```
# Lead Qualification Orchestrator (pseudo)
# Key design goals: idempotency, retries, auditability, and fast response.

def handle_inbound_lead(event):
    lead_key = canonical_lead_key(event)  # email/domain/phone

    if audit.exists("lead", lead_key, event.id):
        return  # idempotent

    audit.start("lead", lead_key, event.id, status="received")

    lead = validate_and_normalise(event)

    # Enrichment (retry with backoff; fall back to partial data)
    enrich = retry(max_attempts=3, backoff="exp")(
        lambda: enrichment.lookup(lead.email, lead.domain)
    )

    score = scoring.compute(lead, enrich)

    owner = routing.assign_owner(score, lead, enrich)

    crm.upsert_lead(lead, enrich, score, owner)
    crm.create_task(owner, "Follow up", due_in_minutes=30 if score.tier=="

    # Fast response: send immediately for hot/warm
    if score.tier in {"hot", "warm"}:
        email.send(
            to=lead.email,
            template=templates.pick(score, enrich),
            variables={"owner_name": owner.name, "meeting_link": owner.cal
        )

    notify.slack(
        channel="#sales-alerts",
        text=f"{score.tier.upper()} lead assigned to {owner.name}: {lead.c
    )

    audit.finish("lead", lead_key, event.id, status="processed", owner=own
```

Run-cost breakdown (typical)

Cost drivers

- enrichment credits (largest line-item)
- email/SMS sending (low)
- automation platform + hosting
- optional LLM (if you add free-text lead reasoning / persona draft)

Example monthly estimate (1,000 leads/month)

- Enrichment API: **$0.05–$0.40 per lead → $50–$400/mo**
- Automation platform/hosting: **$20–$100/mo**
- Email sending: **$5–$30/mo**

- Optional LLM (classification + summary):
  - tokens/month ≈ 1,000 × (2,000 in + 500 out) = 2.5M tokens
  - cost/month = 2.5M × (price_per_token)
  - at $2 / 1M tokens effective blended → **~$5/mo** (example)

Total run cost (typical): $75–$535/mo (mostly enrichment)

SLA + timeline (sample)

Delivery timeline

- Day 1: discovery + mapping
- Day 2–3: enrichment + scoring + CRM wiring
- Day 4: routing + comms + notifications
- Day 5: QA + go-live + dashboard

Operational SLA (example)

- Hot lead auto-ack email: **< 2 minutes** from submission
- Lead assignment: **< 5 minutes** (business hours)
- Workflow uptime target: **99.5%**
- Incident response: P1 within **1 hour**

Sales positioning (what to say)

- "Speed-to-lead is a revenue lever. We can cut response from hours to minutes."
- "We'll make the CRM trustworthy: dedupe, enrichment, and consistent fields."
- "Transparent cost model: enrichment is the only material variable cost."

Suggested pricing tiers (example)

- **Starter — $750/mo**: 1 lead source, basic enrichment, rules-based scoring, Slack alert, HubSpot/Salesforce writeback
- **Growth — $1,500/mo**: multi-source, advanced routing, nurture sequences, dashboards, A/B templates
- **Enterprise — $3,000+/mo**: named-account logic, custom intent signals, multi-region SLA, data warehouse sync, SSO/audit

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Workflow 2 — Customer onboarding (signup → activation → retention)

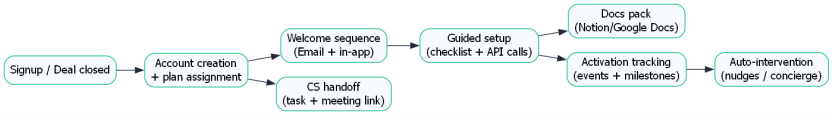
What it does

Automates the "first 14 days" so every customer gets a consistent path to value: account setup, welcome sequence, guided configuration, internal handoffs, and intervention when activation stalls.

Who buys it

- SaaS, membership programs, B2B service providers with repeatable onboarding
- teams where onboarding is consuming support/CS bandwidth

Architecture (diagram)



Step-by-step implementation plan

Phase A — Define success + onboarding milestones (1 day)

1. Define "activated" (e.g., created first project, invited teammate, installed integration)
2. Break into milestones (Day 0, Day 1, Day 3, Day 7, Day 14)
3. Identify drop-off points and required interventions

Phase B — Content + comms (1–2 days)

1. Welcome email series + in-app nudges
2. "Getting started" docs pack (Notion/Docs) generated per customer
3. Calendar links + CS handoff logic

Phase C — Product/API orchestration (1–5 days)

1. Trigger: payment succeeded / contract signed / signup
2. Create account, assign plan, apply default settings
3. Provision integrations (where safe) or generate a guided checklist
4. Track activation events and update lifecycle stage in CRM

Phase D — Risk detection + intervention (1–2 days)

1. If milestone not reached → nudge
2. If high-value account stalling → create CS task + schedule outreach
3. Log reasons (for continuous improvement)

Orchestration pseudocode

```
def onboarding_flow(customer_event):
    cust = crm.get_customer(customer_event.customer_id)

    product.create_account(cust)
    docs.create_workspace_pack(cust, templates=["setup", "faq", "security"

    lifecycle.start_sequence(cust, sequence="welcome_14_day")

    # Milestone monitoring (event-driven where possible)
    for milestone in ["installed_integration", "created_first_project", "i
        ok = wait_for_event(milestone, customer_id=cust.id, timeout_days=7
        if not ok:
            lifecycle.send_nudge(cust, milestone)

    if not analytics.is_activated(cust.id, within_days=14):
        cs.create_task(cust.owner, "Onboarding rescue", priority="high")
        lifecycle.send_concierge_offer(cust)
```

Run-cost breakdown (example: 1,000 onboardings/month)

- Email: $10–$50/mo
- Automation platform: $20–$150/mo
- Product API: usually negligible unless metered
- Optional LLM for personalised guidance (2 calls/customer):
  - tokens/month ≈ 1,000 × 2 × 2,500 = 5M tokens
  - blended example at $2 / 1M → **~$10/mo**

Total run cost (typical): $50–$360/mo

SLA + timeline

- Delivery: **1–2 weeks** depending on product API depth
- SLA (example):
  - welcome email: **< 5 minutes** after signup
  - docs pack generated: **< 15 minutes**
  - CS task created on risk signal: **< 30 minutes**

Sales positioning

- "Reduce early churn by making onboarding consistent and measurable."
- "We'll instrument activation so you can manage onboarding like a funnel."

Suggested pricing tiers

- **Starter — $900/mo**: 1 lifecycle sequence + basic milestone tracking + docs pack
- **Growth — $1,800/mo**: multi-branch onboarding by segment + risk detection + CS tasks
- **Enterprise — $3,500+/mo**: deep product automation, in-app messaging, multi-team handoffs, analytics warehouse

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Workflow 3 — Invoice & payments automation (invoice → dunning → reconciliation)

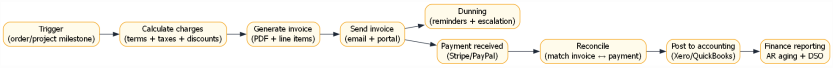
What it does

Creates invoices automatically, sends them, follows up on overdue balances, reconciles payments, and posts clean entries into accounting—reducing finance admin and improving cashflow.

Who buys it

- agencies and professional services
- SMBs with recurring invoicing
- e-commerce or marketplaces (if invoices are required)

Architecture (diagram)



Step-by-step implementation plan

Phase A — Finance rules (0.5–1 day)

1. Invoice triggers (milestones, time logs, subscriptions)
2. Terms (Net 7/14/30), late fees, payment methods
3. Tax/VAT/GST handling
4. Chart of accounts mapping (Xero/QB)

Phase B — Invoicing pipeline (1–3 days)

1. Generate invoice number + PDF template
2. Send invoice (email + portal)
3. Record status transitions (draft → sent → paid → overdue)

Phase C — Dunning (0.5–2 days)

1. Reminder schedule (Day +3, +7, +14)
2. Escalation: notify account manager, pause service (optional)
3. Dispute workflow (route to finance)

Phase D — Reconciliation + accounting sync (1–3 days)

1. Match payment to invoice (by metadata, amount, customer)
2. Post transactions to Xero/QB
3. Create AR aging + DSO reporting

Orchestration pseudocode

```
def invoice_job(trigger):
    invoice = billing.build_invoice(trigger.customer_id, trigger.items)
    pdf = templates.render_invoice_pdf(invoice)

    id = accounting.create_invoice(invoice, attachment=pdf)
    email.send(to=invoice.bill_to, subject=f"Invoice {invoice.number}", at

    schedule.reminders(invoice_id=id, cadence_days=[3,7,14])


def payment_webhook(payment_event):
    inv = accounting.find_invoice_by_payment(payment_event)
    accounting.mark_paid(inv.id, payment_event)
    crm.note(inv.customer_id, f"Invoice {inv.number} paid")
```

Run-cost breakdown (example: 500 invoices/month)

- PDF rendering + automation: $20–$150/mo
- Payment processor webhooks: included
- Accounting API: typically included or low
- Optional LLM for dispute triage (only on disputes)

Total run cost (typical): $20–$200/mo

SLA + timeline

- Delivery: **2–7 days** for standard stacks; longer if custom taxation
- SLA (example):
  - invoice sent after trigger: **< 30 minutes**

- payment reconciliation: **< 15 minutes** after webhook

Sales positioning

- “Get paid faster without adding headcount.”
- “Eliminate manual reconciliation errors and close the books quicker.”

Suggested pricing tiers

- **Starter — $650/mo**: single invoicing source + email delivery + paid reconciliation
- **Growth — $1,250/mo**: dunning schedule + escalation + finance reporting
- **Enterprise — $2,500+/mo**: multi-entity, advanced tax, approvals, dispute flows, audit exports

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Workflow 4 — Support ticket triage & routing (classify → route → draft)

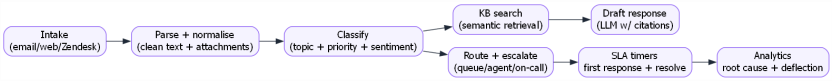
What it does

Categorises and prioritises inbound tickets, routes them to the right queue/agent, suggests KB articles, and drafts responses with citations—improving SLA attainment and reducing handle time.

Who buys it

- SaaS/support orgs with meaningful ticket volume
- IT service desks
- marketplaces with multi-category support

Architecture (diagram)



Step-by-step implementation plan

Phase A — Taxonomy + SLA definition (1 day)

1. Define categories (billing, bug, how-to, account access, etc.)
2. Define priority rules (VIP customers, outage indicators, sentiment)
3. Define SLA timers and escalation rules

Phase B — Retrieval + KB grounding (1–3 days)

1. Choose KB sources (Confluence/Notion/docs)
2. Build embeddings index (or use vendor search)
3. Define “citation required” policy for drafted responses

Phase C — Triage automation (2–5 days)

1. Ingest ticket + attachments

2. Classify + extract entities (account, order id)
3. Route to queue/agent
4. Draft response (optional) with citations + confidence score
5. Human-in-the-loop controls (approve/edit)

Orchestration pseudocode

```
def triage_ticket(ticket):
    text = normalise(ticket.subject + "\n" + ticket.body)

    category = llm.classify(text, labels=TAXONOMY)
    priority = rules.priority(text, ticket.requester, category)

    kb_hits = retrieval.search(text, top_k=5)

    draft = None
    if category in {"how_to", "billing"}:
        draft = llm.draft_reply(text, kb_hits, require_citations=True)

    dest = routing.queue_for(category, priority)
    zendesk.update(ticket.id, tags=[category, priority], assignee=dest)

    if draft:
        zendesk.add_private_note(ticket.id, draft)
```

Run-cost breakdown (example: 2,000 tickets/month)

- Automation platform/hosting: $50–$250/mo
- LLM + retrieval:
  - classification + draft might average 1–2 calls/ticket
  - tokens/month ≈ 2,000 × 2 × 2,500 = 10M tokens
  - blended example at $2 / 1M → **~$20/mo**
- Vector DB: $0–$50/mo (depends on stack)

Total run cost (typical): $70–$370/mo

SLA + timeline

- Delivery: **2–10 days** (faster if taxonomy exists)
- SLA (example):
  - categorisation + routing: **< 2 minutes**
  - draft note attached (if enabled): **< 5 minutes**

Sales positioning

- "Improve SLA attainment without hiring."
- "Reduce handle time with AI drafts that cite your own knowledge base."

Suggested pricing tiers

- **Starter — $800/mo**: classification + routing + SLA timers
- **Growth — $1,800/mo**: KB retrieval + AI draft notes + deflection analytics
- **Enterprise — $4,000+/mo**: multi-brand support, on-call routing, multilingual, custom security controls

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Workflow 5 — Employee onboarding & HR

automation (hire → provision → audit)

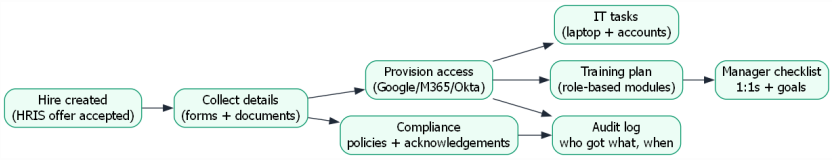
What it does

Automates new-hire paperwork, access provisioning, training assignment, and audit logging so new staff are productive quickly—and compliance doesn't depend on someone remembering a checklist.

Who buys it

- SMBs scaling hiring
- teams with repeatable role-based access needs
- any org with compliance/audit requirements

Architecture (diagram)



Step-by-step implementation plan

Phase A — Role templates + toolchain (1–2 days)

1. Define roles (Sales, CS, Engineering, Ops)
2. Map each role to required apps and groups
3. Confirm system-of-record (BambooHR/HiBob/Workday-lite)

Phase B — HR workflow (1–3 days)

1. Trigger: offer accepted / start date set
2. Collect details (legal name, emergency contact, equipment needs)
3. Generate docs (policy pack, contracts) and capture acknowledgements

Phase C — Provisioning automation (2–7 days)

1. Create Google/M365 user
2. Assign groups, licenses, shared drives
3. Create Slack/Teams, Notion, Jira, GitHub accounts
4. Create IT ticket for equipment
5. Enforce approvals for privileged roles

Phase D — Audit + offboarding readiness (1–2 days)

1. Maintain audit trail of each grant
2. Store access map per employee
3. (Optional) create symmetrical offboarding workflow

Orchestration pseudocode

```
def new_hire_event(hire):
    role = hire.role
    template = role_templates[role]

    user = workspace.create_user(hire.email, name=hire.name)

    for group in template.google_groups:
        workspace.add_to_group(user.id, group)

    slack.invite(user.email, channels=template.slack_channels)
    jira.create_user(user.email)

    training.assign(user.id, modules=template.training_modules)

    audit.log(hire.id, action="provisioned", details=template)

    it.create_ticket(summary=f"Laptop setup for {hire.name}", due=hire.sta
```

Run-cost breakdown (example: 30 hires/month)

- Automation platform/hosting: $20–$100/mo
- Workspace APIs: negligible
- Optional e-sign + doc generation: $10–$50/mo
- Optional LLM for policy Q&A assistant: depends on usage

Total run cost (typical): $30–$200/mo

SLA + timeline

- Delivery: **3–14 days** (depends on toolchain and approvals)
- SLA (example):
  - account provisioning start: within **4 business hours** of HR trigger
  - standard-role access complete: **< 1 business day**

Sales positioning

- "New hires productive on Day 1, and access is consistent and auditable."
- "Reduce security risk by removing ad-hoc manual provisioning."

Suggested pricing tiers

- **Starter — $900/mo**: HR trigger + workspace provisioning + checklists
- **Growth — $2,000/mo**: role templates + approvals + training assignments + audit log
- **Enterprise — $5,000+/mo**: multi-dept approvals, SSO/Okta integrations, compliance reporting, SCIM where available

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Packaging, margin, and next steps

How to package this as a product

Each workflow can be sold as: 1. **Implementation fee** (one-off) for setup + integration 2. **Managed automation subscription** (monthly) for hosting, monitoring, changes 3. **Variable usage pass-through** for metered APIs (enrichment, SMS, LLM)

Suggested delivery add-ons

- Monitoring dashboard + weekly report
- Quarterly optimisation (scoring updates, new templates, routing tweaks)
- Security review + audit export

Suggested next steps (internal)

- Maintain a reusable library: auth connectors, webhook handlers, idempotency store, retry policies
- Create 1-page sales sheets per workflow (pain → outcome → proof → price)
- Standardise SLAs and incident process across all automations